

Trump Suffers
Another Blow
On Mail Votes

Lower Court Judge Says
Plan Is Likely Illegal

By ZACH MONTAGUE
WASHINGTON — As the Supreme Court weighs the legality of a Trump administration plan to change mail-in balloting, a second lower court judge ruled overnight on Sunday that the plan was most likely illegal and should be blocked before the November election.

The ruling by Judge Carl J. Nichols, a Trump appointee, delivered another blow to President Trump’s effort to add new conditions that could make it harder to vote by mail and easier for the federal government to scrutinize state voter rolls while searching for evidence of fraud.

The Supreme Court is considering a similar ruling by a different federal judge based in Massachusetts. Judge Indira Talwani, an Obama appointee, has repeatedly found that the plan was probably unconstitutional and could not be carried out so close to the election without disenfranchising voters.

Judge Nichols, of the Federal District Court in Washington, wrote that the Trump administration had not identified any “evidence that there will be significant fraud in the upcoming elections” if he halted the rule. On the other hand, he wrote, there was an “increased risk that a significant number of otherwise appropriate absentee or mail-in ballots will ultimately not be counted in the upcoming elections” if the rule took effect.

“The public has a strong interest in ensuring that doesn’t happen,” he wrote.

Judge Nichols’s ruling came in a lawsuit brought by a coalition of Democratic-aligned groups, including the Democratic Senatorial Campaign Committee, as well as a number of civil rights organizations. The Massachusetts suit was brought by a coalition of Democratic state attorneys general and voting rights groups.

Judge Nichols ruled in May that he could not stop the Postal Service from drafting the rule or preemptively declare it would necessarily be illegal before it was approved. The Supreme Court similarly ruled last month that it was premature for the courts to intervene to stop Mr. Trump’s plan.

But Judge Nichols said he would review the issue after the Postal Service approved the regulation, which it did in August. His finding that the proposal now should be blocked could offer a preview for how the justices view the issue.

In a court filing on Monday, the Trump administration formally

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Russians cannot take full advantage of digital services — like automated entry to the subway — without submitting biometric data.

Migrants Held
In Tiny Cages,
Inquiry Finds

This article is by Madeleine Ngo, Hamed Aleaziz and David Ovalle.
WASHINGTON — A state-run immigration detention center in the Florida Everglades failed to comply with a host of federal detention standards, creating cramped conditions and confining migrants in “small metal enclosures,” according to a new report by the Department of Homeland Security’s independent watchdog.

The report said the use of the enclosures was unprecedented among facilities that the watchdog, the department’s Office of Inspector General, had previously inspected, and presented “significant risks” to detainees’ health and safety. It focused on a high-profile facility known as Alligator Alcatraz, which came under intense scrutiny before it closed this summer.

The report raised further questions about a facility that became synonymous with the Trump administration’s harsh treatment of immigration detainees. President Trump had joked that the location was in such a remote area that detainees would have to learn “how to run away from an alligator.” It was shuttered after criticism about conditions and cost, and

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In Moscow, the Helpful Robots Double as Spies

By IVAN NECHEPURENKO
MOSCOW — On the surface, today’s Moscow is a technological wonderland. You can use your face to pay for almost anything, like subway fares, or even to finalize the purchase of an apartment. Robots scurry across sidewalks making 15-minute grocery deliveries, and driverless taxis are set to begin commercial service this year.

Underpinning many of the modern amenities is a robust digital infrastructure developed by the city government that has made life not only easier, but also safer. Policing aided by digital tools has helped cement Moscow’s transformation from the raw, unforgiving place it was 25 years ago, plagued by home burglaries, street muggings and murders.

But there is a cost to the convenience and security: an expanding surveillance state.

Moscow’s roughly 300,000 CCTV cameras make it one of the most heavily watched cities in the world. It is impossible to avoid a lens while simply walking through the city. The same cameras that whisk subway passengers through turnstiles are also used to monitor and flag people.

In April, a Russian rock musician



CELESTE SLOMAN FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES
BOB MACKIE, 1939-2026

For over half a century, his glamorous, outrageous costumes beglittered the likes of Cher and Carol Burnett, whose curtain dress, top right, is in the Smithsonian’s permanent collection. Page B11.



GIFT OF BOB MACKIE, VIA SMITHSONIAN



HARRY LANGDON/GETTY IMAGES

NEWS ANALYSIS

Saudis, Besieged by Foes,
Feel Brushed Off by Trump

By VIVIAN NEREIM
RIYADH, Saudi Arabia — Saudi Arabia has increasingly found itself caught in the middle of the war between the United States and Iran. Now, the kingdom’s leadership is assessing dwindling options on how to respond.

In recent weeks, the Iran-allied Houthi militia in Yemen has repeatedly attacked the kingdom, threatening to throttle its ability to export oil and piling pressure on the global economy. But Saudi Arabia has been left frustrated and disappointed by President Trump’s reluctance to confront the Houthis, analysts and former diplomats say.

The kingdom’s diplomatic efforts to engage with Iran have also had limited results. A meeting planned on Monday between officials from Iran, Saudi Arabia and other Persian Gulf countries was abruptly postponed on Sunday night, as the gap between their positions remained vast.

“Right now the Saudis are really frustrated,” said Michael Ratney, a former U.S. ambassador to Saudi Arabia. “In some sense, it’s their worst-case scenario.”

The Saudi government’s Center for International Communication, which fields queries from journalists, did not respond to a request for comment.

The kingdom’s conundrum underscores the heavy costs that

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In Trial of Brain Implant, Woman Speaks by Imagining the Words

By PAM BELLUCK
In a step forward for the cutting-edge field of brain-computer interfaces, a patient with a paralyzing neurological disorder used a brain implant to converse in real time, even when she was simply thinking about what to say, a company announced on Monday.

The development, by the company Paradromics, is the latest advance for these experimental devices, known as B.C.I.s — systems that involve implanting electrodes in the brain that read neurological signals and decode those signals through artificial intelligence.

The 68-year-old Michigan woman, who has lost most of her speaking ability, was able to use the device to have spontaneous conversations via a computer-generated voice, including on the phone with her grandchildren.

When she physically tried to speak, her brain generated signals that were read by the electrodes, transmitted through A.I. and displayed on the computer screen, which spoke the words aloud. The system could also produce speech when the woman imagined what to say without moving her speaking muscles.

Because the Paradromics system is wireless and doesn’t require the patient to be connected by a cord to a computer, experts said, it offers a demonstration of how patients who have lost the ability to speak might be able to

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His Texas impeachment trial in 2023 stands out as the defining episode in a scandal-plagued career. PAGE A16

McConnell Returns to the Hill
The senator from Kentucky, 84, had been absent for more than three months after a health incident. PAGE A15

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Racial and political tensions have flared after members of an ethnic minority were accused of an assassination plot based on a private phone call. PAGE A4

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China Warns of A.I. Threat
Even as Beijing urges the U.S. not to hype the dangers of A.I., its own spy chief is framing the technology as a danger to party security. PAGE A11

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Companies at the artificial intelligence forefront posted declines after industry leaders expressed worries about the safety of the technology. PAGE B1

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The 10-year Treasury yield topped 5 percent, fueled by war, A.I. and the runaway spending on both. PAGE B1

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Quarterbacks such as Josh Allen of the Bills and Caleb Williams of the Bears had spellbinding efforts. PAGE B9



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The French-Canadian singer looked fragile but defiant in her first full concert performance in six years. PAGE C2

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Joan Birman, then 92, thought her major discoveries were behind her. Then a girl, 15, contacted her. PAGE D4

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A patient lived with a kidney from a genetically modified pig before receiving a human organ transplant. PAGE D3

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